emphasis should have been on intelligence-led operations to strike at the top tier of the insurgents. Military claimed to have carried out intelligence-led operations, but the leadership of TTP remained intact. A counter-insurgency force should have been raised to replace armed forces gradually to avoid protracted engagement of military within the country. This engagement might continue for years.

However, three aspects were perplexing. First, the military strategists chose to ignore the element of surprise; an effective 'means to gain superiority' on the battlefield (Clause Witz, 1976). The publicity of these operations was early and loud enough to be noticed and anticipated by the enemy that took precautionary measures. The army probably wanted to avoid collateral damage; therefore, it warned all beforehand so that civilians could leave in good time.

Secondly, mainly due to the above reason, most of the top leadership of Swat TTP, including Maulvi Fazlullah, could be neither arrested nor killed. The news of Maulvi Fazlullah being seriously wounded was also denied by TTP sources (*The Nation*, 2009). Rather the TTP spokesperson, Muslim Khan, in an audio message sent to a TV channel threatened the people of Swat of dire consequences for siding with the army. He claimed that Fazlullah and other top Taliban leaders were alive and would continue their struggle (*The Daily Times*, 2009). It turned out to be true to some extent.

Thirdly, melting away of TTP forces created a scare. Afghan Taliban had also melted away within 35 days of the US attack on Afghanistan, but within two months, they started the guerrilla war and after 16 years, they were still fighting with the international forces. The fear turned true as Fazlullah and his followers found sanctuaries in Nuristan and Kunar provinces of Afghanistan.

All the militants should have been accounted for: how many were killed; how many were arrested; how many had slipped away and more importantly where? At least it became clear from subsequent activities of these elements that they took refuge in Kunar and Nuristan provinces of Afghanistan, which were closer to Pakistan border.

While this operation was being wrapped up, the operation 'Rah-e-Nijat' (the salvation path) was launched against the TTP in South Waziristan. It was the largest and most ambitious COIN campaign in the country's history, involving 60,000 troops, of which 45,000 were deployed in a combat role and 15,000 in a support one (Lodhi, 2010).